VIKING WEAPONS

Vikings used a variety of weapons according to the quantity of metal they could afford. Spears were the most common as the heads required little steel and shafts could easily be replaced if they splintered on the battlefield. A basic axe was something even the poorer farmer would possess for his domestic use, while swords were items of great value, owned by only the very successful Viking raider and passed down through generations. As signs of status and wealth, weapons were often decorated.

FIRE ARROW

Tar-soaked linen, set alight to spray burning tar on impact

SAIL SPLITTER

Possibly shot at sails or rigging

CAVALRY ARROW

BARBED ARROW

Barbed head for difficult removal from target

SHORT BODKIN ARROW

Compact head designed to pierce chainmail

Wider tipped for firing on horses

Leaf-shaped head of tempered steel

Arrows
Arrowheads varied enormously in shape and size. Shafts were about 70 to 80cm (28–32in) long and arrows were fired from a bow made of ash, elm, or yew, with a range of around 200m (650ft).

Spears
Spears were thrust rather than hurled. Vikings used smaller javelins for throwing, carrying three at a time, as well as an axe for defence once the javelins were released.

DANE AXE

Axe shaft measured the height of the man wielding it two-handed

Blade showing the swirling effect of forging by pattern welding

Axes
These ranged from smaller battle-axes also used domestically, to the two-handed broad axe, which had to be used for quick hit-and-run attacks as the Viking could not carry a shield at the same time.

BATTLE-AXE

Tempered steel blade

Shaft of hard wood such as yew or ash

Petersen type split design pommel

DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

Bound leather grip

Swords
Viking blades were pattern welded, forged by twisting strips of metal together, beating and heating them, repeating the procedure several times for added strength. Sheaths hung on the left side so the right-handed warrior could easily withdraw his sword across his body.

Double-edged tempered steel blade

Silver edging

SCABBARD AND BALDRIC

Bronze buckle

Leather baldric (belt to hold sword)

DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

Typical triangular pommel

Woven leather grip

Leather scabbard with runic design